

Sacramental Theology

2015/2023

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Course Code:

Type of Course: Bachelor's Degree (BTh)

Subject Area: Dogmatic Theology

Module Title: Sacramental Theology

Credits: 3 Credit

Class Venue: (A304 Thu 2:30-4:30; A310 Friday 12:00 – 02:00)

Length of Teaching: (Total: 14 Weeks)

Class Taught by Abba Hailegebriel Girma (PhD, EdD)

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Module Description

This module is biblically and theologically grounded, which is a theological, biblical, and liturgical examination of the sacraments. By studying the central beliefs and communal practices of the Sacraments, students will learn to articulate the feature of the sacramental life in Orthodox worship. This course will introduce students to theological reflection on the sacraments. The focus will be on the Orthodox tradition.

Intended Learning Outcomes:

This module will assist students to grow in the following knowledge, skills, and attitudes:

Knowledge –

- familiarity with theological understandings of the sacraments through scriptures, especially in the Orthodox Tradition;
- Have a good understanding of the meaning of sacrament and theology.

Skills –

- ability to explain the sacraments, aware of important currents in the theology of sacraments.
- ability to explore the theology of sacraments presented in the Christian spiritual life.

Attitudes –

- Care and concern for the importance of sacraments in the Orthodox Faith and Holy Tradition.
- a well-developed sense of the place of a sacramental view for personal spirituality and ecclesial identity.

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Teaching and Learning Methods

This course will be delivered using a combination of lectures and article reviews. The ethos of the course is that learning is a shared experience between all the participants. The role of the course leader is to facilitate the learning experience and not to be the possessor of any special knowledge, wisdom, or authority. Hence participation and dialogue on all aspects of the course are encouraged and welcomed. There will be discussion boards for students to discuss among themselves different aspects of the course, and the course leader will participate in the discussions when it is appropriate. The course leader encourages students to work together on homework assignments. Use the discussion board to post your questions and read the responses from your classmates. Exams are on an individual basis. Any questions on exams should be directed to the course leader. The course leader will add information to the exams if there are experiencing particular problems. For this, a course handout will be provided and the main issues will be discussed in the class with a PowerPoint presentation. In addition to this, reading documents, which are extracted from different sources, will be provided for individual reflection and communal discussion.

Expectations

Students will be expected to read and analyze material from the course handouts. They will also be expected to attend and participate in class. The course leader will attempt to provide interesting and informative material for them to read, give helpful lectures, provide activities that challenge and stimulate interest, be available to answer any questions they may have, and provide fair and timely evaluations of their achievement.

Course Structure

The following is the structure of the course:

Week	Topics	Sub-Topics	Descriptions
Chapter One Sacrament in General			
Week 1 11-17/07/2015 (March 20-26/ 2023)	**Introduction to the module – Sacramental Theology**	• Course Outline and Syllabus • Assignments/presentation • What is Sacrament? • What is Theology?	Orientations to the module outline, syllabus, expectations, and assignments Introduction to one another and group norms
Week 2 18-24/07/2015 (March 27- Apr. 2/ 2023)	**Sacramental Theology: Doctrine**	• Dogmatic Theology and Symbolic Formation • The object of Dogmatic and Symbolic Theology	Lecture and Class Discussion and Exercise

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Week 3 25-30/07/2015 (Apr. 3-9/2023)	**Sacramental Theology: Holy Tradition**	• Holy Tradition in Orthodox Context • Prayer • The Structure of the Prayer • Article Review	Lecture and Exercise with Article Reviews
Week 4 2-8/08/2015 (Apr. 10-16/2023)	**Holy Week & The Holy Pascha (Easter Sunday)**		
Week 5 9-15/08/2015 (Apr.17-23/2023)	**The Holy Pascha (Easter Week)**		
Chapter Two **Sacramental Theology: Putting on Our God and Savior Jesus Christ** **"But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires." (Rom. 13:14)**			
Week 6 16-22/08/2015 (Apr.24-30/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Baptism**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives	Lecture and Class Discussion
Week 7 23-29/08/2015 (May 1-7/2023)	**Mid-Exam**	• Exam Schedule or Article Review	Assessment Period
Week 8 30/08-6/09/2015 (May 8-14/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Confirmation**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives	Lecture with examples, Class Discussion and Exercise
Week 9 7-13/09/2015 (May 15-21/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Eucharist**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives • Names Given to Holy Eucharist • The Divine Liturgy	Lecture with examples and Class Discussion
Chapter Three **Sacramental Theology: Spiritual and Reparative Life in Our God and Savior Jesus Christ**			
Week 10 14-20/09/2015 (May 22-28/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Penance**	• Historical Background • Biblical Contexts ➢ The Rite of Confession in Old & New Testament Evidence • Theological Perspectives • Forgiveness	Lecture with examples, Class Discussion and Exercise

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Week 11 21-27/09/2015 (May 29 – Jun. 4/ 2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Anointing of the Sick**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives	Lecture with examples, Class Discussion and Exercise
Chapter Four **Sacramental Theology: Service Life in Our God and Savior Jesus Christ**			
Week 12 28/09-4/10/2015 (Jun. 5-11/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Ordination**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives	Lecture with examples and Class Discussion
Week 13 5-11/10/2015 (Jun. 12-18/2023)	**Holy Sacrament of Marriage**	• Biblical Contexts • Theological Perspectives	Lecture with examples and Class Discussion and Exercise
Week 14 (12-18/10/2015 (Jun. 19-25/2023)	**Final Revision and Article Review**	• Revision and Article Review	Article Presentation

Main Reference:

Schmemann, A. (1998). *For the life of the world: Sacrament and theology*. New York: St. Vladimir's Seminary.

Course Work Assessment

Students will be provided a list of questions related to each topic discussed in the class to study and prepare themselves for the exam. On exam day, the student will choose four or five questions out of the list and give the answer in a separate paper. In order to pass, the module students must complete the following pieces of assessed work.

Assignment No.	Assessment type	Notes	% of formal assessment
2	Class Exercises	4 Exercises	4*5=20%
3	Mid term Exam or Article Review	1 Exam or Article Review	30%
4	Final Examination	1 Exam	50%

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Grading

Result will be given based on student's class participation and interactive discussion on the reading documents, and of course the final exam.

A+	96 – 100
A	91 – 95
A-	86 – 90
B+	81 – 85
B	76 – 80
B-	71 – 75
C+	66 – 70
C	61 – 65
C-	56 – 60
D	50 – 55
F	Below 50

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity is a basic guiding principle for all academic activity, allowing the pursuit of scholarly activity in an open, honest, and responsible manner. In according with the Code of Conduct, students must not engage in or tolerate academic dishonesty. This includes, but is not limited to cheating, plagiarism, fabrication of information or citations, facilitating acts of academic dishonesty by others, unauthorized possession of examinations, submitting work of another person, or work previously used without informing the lecturer, or tampering with the academic work of other students.

Week One

What is meant by Sacrament?

"Church life centered on the sacred practices (sacramentalism). The Church faithful looked to the rites of the Church which they believed were able to infuse divine grace into the participants." (Grenz, 2000, p. 513)

- The word '*sacrament*' developed from the Greek word '*mysterion*' and the Latin word '*sacramentum*'.
- '*Mysterion*' means 'something hidden or secret' – our word '*mystery*'.

- In general, the word "*sacrament*" in Greek means "*mystery*", and our Lord Jesus Christ has been called by St. Paul "a great mystery" (1 Tim 3:16).

Sacrament is an invisible grace we receive by practicing a visible rite, and a visible sign or substance performed by a priest.

Sacrament is an integral to Christian faith and theology and much sacramental theology takes its bearings from the New Testament.

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The Old Testament, however, although a major part of the Christian Bible, is a collection of writings that are all pre-Christian in origin.

Saint John Chrysostom states:

> "It is called a mystery because what we believe is not the same as what we see, but we see one thing and believe another ..... In every sacrament there is the combination of an outward visible sign with an inward spiritual grace" (Ware, 1997).

Purpose of Sacraments

The Holy Spirit works in the Church through the Sacraments, giving us His gifts, blessing and comfort, and teaches us and guides us to the way of truth.

"*But the comforter, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My Name, He will teach you all things ....I said to you*" (John 14:26).

What is Theology?

The word '*Theology*' comes from Greek words: '*Theos*' which means 'God', and 'Logos' which means 'Word'. Literally, '*Theology*' is '*God-talk*', i.e., the act discoursing, writing or studying about God. (Cottrell, 2006:9)

- Theology is a knowledge about God or wisdom about God.
- Orthodox is an adjective which explains the precise truth.
- Mystical Union with God.

Orthodox theology is taken to be an experience of Divine-human communion within the liturgical services of the community of all believers and the spiritual life of each of its individual members.

Sacramental Theology

Sacramental Theology is a sacred ordinance through which the faithful receive an invisible grace under the type of an external sign, visible or perceptible.

The Sacraments are a holy ordinance in Church through which the faithful accept an invisible grace under the type of an external sign or visible. Christ Himself instituted them.

Bulgakov explains,

> "Our Lord has been pleased to establish a definite way, accessible to all, for the reception of the Grace of the Holy Spirit, in the holy mysteries. The mysteries (sacraments) are sacred acts, when, under a visible sign, there is conferred a definite, invisible gift of the Holy Spirit" (1988, p. 110).

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Week Two & Three

Sacramental Theology: Doctrine and Holy Tradition

Aim

- This session intends to introduce students to the concept of Sacramental Theology: Doctrine and Holy Tradition.

Learning Outcomes

- Students have some understanding of what constitutes a Doctrine and what constitutes Holy Tradition

Doctrine

The word doctrine comes from the Latin '***doctrina***'. It means teaching or instruction and is closely associated with the word '***catechesis***'. It is used both in the active sense of the imparting of knowledge and in the passive sense of what is taught (Cottrell, 200 p. 10).

Our God and Savior Jesus Christ was a teacher, and His teaching was what He had received from the Father (Jn 3:13; 5.17; 8:25-27). This teaching had continuity with that of Moses and the Prophets, but it added to and completed it. Our Lord Jesus Christ taught with authority and power (Mt 7:29), and human's eternal 'salvation' depended on the way this teaching was accepted (Lk. 9:26). After Christ's Resurrection and Ascension, the Apostles saw their task as that of handing on faithfully what they had received from Christ (Rom 16:17; Gla. 1:8; Eph. 4:14; Tim. 1:9). The word doctrine was used not only of their teaching (1 Tim. 4:6,16) but of the content of their preaching (Acts 2:42). It was the good news, the Gospel, and from it stemmed the new way of the Christian life.

The Purpose of Dogmatic and Symbolic Theology

Dogmatic Theology is a precise expression of the Orthodox faith. A definition of dogma includes these characteristic notes.

- We can confirm that dogma is a truth revealed to human being by God. This value of Christian dogma is different from pagan practices.
- The dogma is a truth unchangeable in the Church once given forever.
- The dogma is a truth that brings about salvation and eternal life.

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- Dogma aims at eternal life and salvation.

  The first feature message of the dogma is to be a truth revealed, to be a truth mere expressed in the true foundation of Christian revelation. This revealed nature of the dogma has accumulated multiples name, such as the teaching of our Lord Jesus Christ mentioned in Eph. 2:15 and Col 2:14; the dogma of divinity and the Christian dogma.
- Dogma is given for certain roles; that is, for salvation is impossible without faith. Obviously, dogma is the purpose of this faith.
- Dogma is the Church theological truth. In order to distinguish the canons, the moral teaching and the dogmatic teaching, it is revealed by God.
- Dogma stands for our faith in Triune God, and carries one message, namely, our communion with God the Father, our Lord Jesus Christ, the Incarnate (***LOGOS***) Word of God, Holy Spirit.
- Dogma is a truth formulated and defended by the Holy Church. This is a definite message of the Church dogma conception.
- Dogma is revealed truth, formulated preached and intruded by the Holy Church.

The Ethiopian Orthodox *Tewahedo* Church dogmatic theology deals with doctrine and Christian moral teaching. Over time, Church has drawn up list of her most important beliefs. This is called **"Creed"**, a name driving form the Latin word **'Credo'**. Credo means **'I believe'**.

Creed: - A concise statement of what is believed. (Dictionary of World Religions)

Creed is divided in to four parts:

- The first is about God the Father.
- The second is about God the Son.
- The third is about God the Holy Spirit.
- The fourth is about other essential Christian beliefs.

The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed is the most important Creed in our Orthodox Tradition. Creed is used in many forms of Christian worship such as Baptism, Conformation, and the Holy Eucharist.

Holy Tradition in Orthodox Context

What is Tradition? We can declare to be a traditional Church, one which follows the Tradition of the early, holy Church fathers. Indeed, the question of the meaning of Tradition is one of the major topics bearing upon the Orthodox Church today. In attempting to grasp

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the character of Tradition, we are directed to consider not only the character of our relationship with the past but also the very character of our Christian faith –its context, its source and its aim.

In modern practice the term ***'Tradition'*** is frequently defined in chronological terms, indicating that which is in some way accepted or donated from the past. The highlighting here is enormously on the past, and behind this explanation is a very post-enlightenment view that that which is from the past is essentially out-of-date.

However, the term 'Tradition' comes from the Latin ***'Traditio'***. Its basic meaning is not chronological but active meaning, referring to the 'handing over' 'passing on' and 'giving over" by someone of something to someone. Therefore, Holy Tradition is given over and passed on within the Holy Church from the time of our Lord Jesus Christ's disciples right down to the present time.

St Paul says "…stand firm and hold to the **Traditions** which you were taught by us, either by word of mouth or by letter" (II Thess. 2:15). Apostle Jude also writes, "*Dear friends, although I was very eager to write to you about the salvation we share, I felt compelled to write and urge you to contend for the faith that was once for all entrusted to God's holy people*" (Jude 1:3).

Holy Tradition is the whole experience and life of the entire Church transferred from generation to generation and from place to place. Holy Tradition is the actual life of the Holy Church itself. All parts of Holy Tradition are actually linked together. None may be separated from the other or from the wholeness of the life of the Holy Church. All come alive in the life of the Holy Church in every age, in every time and in all place. Holy Tradition is the unique form of receiving the truth.

Prayer

> "***Prayer** is a great weapon, a rich treasure, a wealth that is never exhausted, an undisturbed refuge, a cause of tranquillity, the root of a multitude of blessings, and their source.*" **St. John Chrysostom**

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Prayer is a word by which man communicates with his Creator in Faith, thanking and beseeching Him for the forgiveness of his sin (the Law of Kings 14:528). The basis of prayer is divine word which runs "*Ask, and it will be given to you, seek, and you will find, knock and it will be opened to you*". (Mt. 7:7).

In general, prayer is a common feature of worship among faithful. Prayer follows a set pattern or forms of words. Through prayer faithful hope to experience God for themselves. Prayer usually takes the following forms:

- Praising God's greatness
- Thanksgiving for God's goodness and providence
- Requesting God's forgiveness or other acts of blessings
- Approaching God on behalf of others (intercession).

For prayer, there is a particular time and place. The times during which the clergy and the laity go to church are morning and evenings.

The Structure of Prayer

As the Law of Kings describes, prayer is the faithful's method of communicating with the Lord. In Prayer the faithful thank-the Lord, worship Him, confessing their sin and seeking on their part the method of delighting the Lord. The following instructions are laid down for the person who uses confession's prayer.

- Firstly, the person shall stand up, as commanded in the words of the Lord: "And when you stand praying, if you hold anything against anyone, forgive him, so that your Father in heaven may forgive you your sins" (Mk. 11:25).
- Secondly, the person shall tighten himself/ herself with a belt, as the Lord commands: "*Let your loins be girded about, and your lights burning*;" (Luke 12:35).
- Thirdly, the person shall turn in the direction of the east, because the EOTC teaches that the Lord will come into view in the second coming.
- Fourthly, the person shall prostrate and kneel down himself or herself. Prostration teaches the faithful to remember the Passion of Christ.

As King David says, "***Seven times a day I praise you for your righteous laws***" (Ps. 119:164). The Spiritual father orders daily prayers to the faithful. Believers shall prayer seven times a

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day. These are: (1) In the morning, (2) at the third hour, (3) at noon, (4) at ninth hour, (5) at sunset, (6) at bedtime and (7) at midnight.

Prayer is the part of Church worship or faith life. Worship is giving God the glory which is due to Him. "Come, let us bow down in worship, let us kneel before the LORD our Maker; for he is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, the flock under his care." Ps. 95:6-7. In relation to prayer, Faith is the willingness to act on God's Word with total trust. God delights in strong faith. The Holy Bible says, "*... Without faith it is impossible to please God, because anyone who comes to him must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him"* (Heb. 11:6). St. Paul says, "Faith comes from hearing the message, and the message is heard through the word about Christ" (Rom. 10:17). The Word of God generates faith and faith creates power for prayer. So, the Word of God, faith and prayer are directly related.

References

Cottrell, J. (2006). *The faith once for all: Bible doctrine for today*. Joplin: College Press.

Haffner, P. (1999). *The sacramental mystery*. Wiltshire: Cromwell Press.

Payton, J. (2007). *Light from the Christian East: An introduction to the Orthodox Tradition.* Downers Grove: IVP.

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Week Six & Eight

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Sacramental Theology: Putting on Our God and Savior Jesus Christ

"But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires." (Rom. 13:14)

- **Holy Sacrament of Baptism**
- **Holy Sacrament of Confirmation**
- **Holy Sacrament of Eucharist**

Aim

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- This session intends to introduce students to the concept of the Holy Sacrament of Baptism and the Holy Sacrament of Confirmation

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Learning Outcomes

- Students will understand the spiritual significance of the sacraments of Baptism and Confirmation and become familiar with the rituals associated with them.

The Holy Sacrament of Baptism

What is the Ethiopian Orthodox *Tewahedo* Church's understanding of ***'Baptism'*** and how, according to the ***Orthodox Tradition***, is baptism to be lived out?

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The Meaning of Baptism

Baptism literally means immersion in water. The universal meaning of baptism is that of "**starting anew**," of dying to an old, way of life and being born again into a new way of life (Jn. 3:3). Thus, baptism is always connected with repentance which means a moral conversion, a "**change of mind**," a change in living from something old and bad to something new and good.

Biblical Contexts

The Holy Sacrament of Baptism is to be a sign of commitment to Christ. It is not just plain water, but the water included in God's command and combined with God's Word. As St Mark's Gospel says, baptism has been obligatory for all Christians (Mk. 16:16).

According to the Gospel of John, a human being must be baptized and be born again of water and the Holy Spirit, in order to enter the Kingdom of God (Jn. 3:3). This biblical evidence teaches that baptism is administered by order of our Lord Jesus Christ. That is why Christians believe that baptism is the main entrance to the Church.

In the Orthodox Christian Church, the practice of baptism takes on a new and particular significance. It no longer remains merely a sign of moral change and spiritual rebirth. It becomes very specifically the act of a person's death and resurrection in and with Jesus. Christian baptism is the faithful's participation in the event of Easter. It is a "*new birth by water and the Holy Spirit*" into the Kingdom of God (Jn 3:5). The faithful are immersed in the baptismal font in ***the Name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit***. Entering the font, which symbolizes the tomb and the womb- death to the old person life to the new, faithful joins Christ in His burial; coming up out of it, the faithful take part in Christ's resurrection from the tomb. The faithful are "*born again*," literally "*born from above*", into a new life in our Lord Jesus Christ.

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The Signs and the Symbols of Baptism

Holy Baptism is considered as an act of obedience symbolizing the believer's faith in a crucified, buried, and risen our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, as well as the believer's death to sin, the burial of the old life, and the resurrection to walk in newness of life in Jesus Christ. It is the gift of Christ's Death and a testimony of the afterlife of the dead.

Tsirpanlis stated that the Holy Baptism is the symbol of Christ's death and resurrection:

> Baptism symbolizes Christ's death, for, as Saint Paul says, through Baptism we are buried with the Lord. The three, immersions signify the three days of the Lord in the tomb. As Christ died once and for all we must be baptized once and they crucify the Lord a new who have themselves re-baptized, after they had been baptized lawfully (1991:108).

As St. Paul describes baptism as a burial (Romans 6:7), it links the believer with the crucified Savior, illustrating the call of Jesus to take up the cross. It also symbolizes resurrection; the person, who is baptized, comes up out of the water, signifying that they have received new life in Christ. The Holy Baptism is which sanctifies and purifies. The Holy Baptism is also necessary because it offers:

(1) the second birth,
(2) Newness of life,
(3) being a member of the Holy Church,
(4) being buried with Christ,
(5) Crucifixion of our old life and
(6) Resurrection.

Baptism in the Church begins with the rejection of Satan and the acceptance of Christ. Before being baptized, a person—or his/her Godparents for him/her—officially proclaims the symbol of the Christian faith, the Creed. Because the Godparent speaks on behalf of the child, sponsors his entrance into the Church and "receives" the child out of the baptismal waters into the Church, and cares for his/her spiritual life, the Godparent must be a member of the Church. Through the act of immersion, the baptized person dies in this world and is born again in the resurrection of Christ into eternal life. He/she is clothed with the "garment of righteousness" symbolized by the white baptismal robe which is the "new humanity" (Jn 3, Rom 5, 1 Cor 15). Furthermore, the newly baptized faithful are dressed in white after the baptism, symbolizing their new life as a servant of Christ. Here we can understand how

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sacramental theology is involved within the Orthodox Christian Ministries and how spiritual life is growing in the Holy Sacrament of Baptism as a result of the readings done:

> The person is immersed in the water. At this moment, the grace of the Holy Spirit descends on him and gives him a new life, washing away all his sins, and giving him the first taste of eternal life by uniting him to Jesus, the Son of God (Dmitri, 1980, p. 30).

The baptismal service is also a symbol of spiritual cleanliness. The Holy Baptism is imperishable.

The Sacrament of Confirmation

The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation is the Church's mystery through which the faithful are granted the gift of the Holy Spirit who can confirm the faithful alone in the new life given to the faithful through the Sacrament of Baptism (Acts 8: 14-17; 19: 5-6). "Confirmation" means "strengthening" because we are strengthened by the Gifts of the Holy Spirit (Isaiah 11:2).

The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation, also called Chrismation, is always done in the Orthodox Church together with baptism. This sacrament gives the faithful the power of growth in new life and keeps the faithful firm in the feature of truth (1 John 2:20-21). Through this sacrament, the faithful receive the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

Isaiah 11:2 says,

> "The Spirit of the Lord will rest on him— the Spirit of wisdom and of understanding, the Spirit of counsel and of power, the Spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the Lord."

The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation is basically the perfection and completion of the Sacrament of Baptism, and that is why Confirmation immediately follows Baptism in the Church. By Baptism, a new code of spiritual life is given to the beginner; by Confirmation, he/she is gifted by all the gifts of the Holy Spirit which are essential for the progress and growth of that life. By Baptism, a new way of life is opened for the Christian; by Confirmation, he/she is strengthened for this extensive lesson of spiritual growth in the Christian struggle as a spiritual soldier in the army of Jesus Christ.

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Biblical Contexts

To understand the Holy Sacrament of Confirmation one has to appreciate that Our Lord Jesus Christ assured that there would be an outpouring of the Holy Spirit. This clearly happened on Pentecost Day with the powerful action of the Holy Spirit bringing about the birth of the Holy Christian Church.

The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation contains outward signs that show a deeper spiritual happening. The laying on of hands indicates the coming of the Holy Spirit during the sacrament with this being accompanied by the anointing with oil. This would be expected to be included in the sacrament since there is a very Scriptural basis for it. In the Epistle of Hebrews, the theological teaching concerning Baptism and the laying on of hands is recorded among the first aspects of Christian instruction (Heb. 6:1-3). The biblical illustration for Confirmation is "laying on of hands," as it is explained in the Book of the Acts of the Apostles (Chapters 8 and 19). It is always accompanied by the receiving of the Holy Spirit. "When they (Samaritans) believed . . . they were baptized" by Philip the deacon.

> "When the apostles at Jerusalem heard that (people at) Samaria had received the word of God, they sent to them Peter and John, who came down and prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit, for it had not yet fallen on any of them, but they had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. Then they *laid their hands on them* and they received the Holy Spirit" (Acts 8: 12-17).
>
> "On hearing this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. And when Paul had *laid his hands upon them*, the Holy Spirit came on them" (Acts 19: 5-6).

Therefore, it is the sacrament through which we receive the Holy Spirit.

Theological Perspectives

The important part of the Holy Sacrament of Confirmation is what the sacrament impacts. As stated above Christ assured an outpouring of the Holy Spirit. The sending of the Holy Spirit implies more than the reduction of sins and new birth. It brings commissioning, a nourishing for the prophetic task the follower of our Lord Jesus Christ is called to live. The task involves evangelization next to the example of the disciples after the Pentecost day, working for love, justice, and peace, protecting innocent human life, and living out the call to the Christian sacrament.

The Grace of the Holy Spirit is now the real presence of a *Divine Power*, and a participation in the divine energy acting in us to deify us. With this power and blessing, humanity can grow and develop

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in the likeness of Triune God who gradually will reveal Himself. The Holy Confirmation is a mystery where the Holy Spirit dwells to fortify against evil and provides victory in spiritual struggles. In general, The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation is the completion of Christian initiation which was begun in Baptism.

Discussion Points

1. What are the effects of the Holy Sacrament of Baptism?
2. Where is Confirmation found in Scripture?
3. Can you find examples in Scripture of famous people who were baptized and confirmed in the faith?
4. What are the effects of the Holy Sacrament of Confirmation?

References

Dmitri, B. (1980). *Orthodox Christian Teaching: An Introduction to the Orthodox Faith*. NY: Orthodox Church in America.

Tsirpanlis, C.N. (1991). *Introduction to Eastern Patristic Thought and Orthodox Theology*. Minnesota: The Liturgical Press.

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Class Taught by	Abba Hailegebriel Girma (PhD, EdD)
E-Mail:	abbahg1@gmail.com

Week Nine

Sacramental Theology: Putting on Our God and Savior Jesus Christ

"But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires." (Rom. 13:14)

- **Holy Sacrament of Baptism**
- **Holy Sacrament of Confirmation**
- **Holy Sacrament of Eucharist**

Objectives

- To go into the depths of The Sacrament of Holy Eucharist to meet our Lord Jesus Christ and understand the Salvation through sacrifice of His love.

Scriptural Verse

"*Jesus took bread, blessed and broke it, and gave it to them and said: Take, eat; this is My body. Then He took the cup, and when He had given thanks He gave it to them, and they all drank from it. And He said to them: This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many*" (Mk. 14:22- 23).

"*Most assuredly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you. Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day*" (Jn. 6:53-54).

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Lesson Guidelines

The Lord Jesus instituted the Holy Eucharist on Covenant Thursday shortly before His arrest and trial. After He celebrated the Rite of Passover of the Jews, He washed the feet of His disciples, as a sign of repentance and preparation, then sat down and instituted the Passover of the New Covenant "Eucharist" (Mt. 26:26-28, Mk 14:22-23, Lk. 22:17-20 and Jn. 6:47-51)

It is a Holy Sacrament by which the believer eats the Holy Body and Precious Blood of our Lord Jesus Christ.

The Sacrament of Holy Eucharist

The Holy Eucharist is the center of the worship and life of the Church. The Holy Eucharist is also the heart of the entire Christian life, with the Christian's initiation into the Church completed by the reception of the Holy Eucharist. In addition, all of the other the Church Mysteries (Sacraments) and work of the Church are oriented towards this sacrament. The Church properly uses the word 'Mystery' for sacrament. It is in this transcendent mystery of God's love revealed in the Holy Eucharist for his people that the faithful (the Christian community) unite themselves with the heavenly Divine Liturgy by uniting themselves to sacrifice of Jesus Christ on the Holy Cross and to His Resurrection.

The Meaning of Eucharist

The term *'Eucharist'* means thanksgiving. This name is given to the sacred life to the whole act of gathering, praying, reading the Holy Scriptures and proclaiming God's Word, and eating and drinking His Body and Blood in communion with Him. The word eucharist is used because the all-embracing meaning of the Lord's Supper is that of thanksgiving to God for all that He has done in making, saving and glorifying the world.

The Holy Eucharist is called the "sacrament of sacraments" in the Orthodox Tradition. It is also called the "sacrament of the Church." This Sacrament has the greatest importance among the Seven Church Sacraments. It is also called the 'Mystery of Mysteries' or the 'Crown of Sacraments'; for all the Sacraments are crowned by the Eucharist. As pointed out above, the Holy Eucharist is the center of the Church's life. Everything in the Church leads to the

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eucharist, and all things flow from it. It is the completion of all of the Church's sacraments—the source and the goal of all of the Church's doctrine.

The Holy Eucharist expresses, reveals and accomplishes within history the Church itself, principally how it will be, when the Kingdom of God prevails. In Orthodox Tradition, the Holy Eucharist is an icon of the Kingdom of God: an icon of the future and not of the past. In the Holy Eucharist, the Church moves from the present world and history, and lives and moves in the ***eschata,*** in the Last Times. The Church's true home is the Kingdom of God and not this world. And precisely because the Holy Eucharist is an icon of the Kingdom of God, it must be celebrated with splendor. That is why the liturgical guide specifies that the Holy Eucharist is to be celebrated in the Church.

Names Given to Holy Eucharist

It has number of names according to its a range of meanings and aspects. It is named:

- Holy Communion, because of the action and its results as we communicate with our Lord Jesus Christ Himself in this Holy Sacrament.
- Holy Eucharist, which means Thanksgiving or Blessing, and explains its Sacramental aspect.
- Holy Sacrifice, referring to the immolation of our Lord Jesus Christ on the Cross, where Jesus Christ shed His Blood, as a wounded, for our (human being) salvation.
- The Lord's Supper, which refers to the event at which it was instituted.
- The Mysterious Supper.
- Divine Liturgy

The reason of the sacrifice on the Cross was the reconciliation of human beings with God, the atonement for the sins of human beings and their expiation, in general. Whereas the Sacrifice of the Holy Eucharist is offered for human beings, it is the application of the universal benefits of the sacrifice of the Cross, to those for whom the Holy Eucharist is celebrated.

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The Institution of the Holy Eucharist

Christ Himself gave to us the Sacrament of the Holy Eucharist on the evening of the Mystical Supper, a few hours before His voluntary Passion. As the Lord Christ instituted the Sacrament of the Holy Eucharist (Mt. 26:26-29), He is regard as the first celebrant of the Holy Eucharist. He gave His own flesh and blood. He commanded His apostles to continue the celebration in remembrance of Him and based on His percept, the apostles also continued to celebrate the Holy Eucharist (1 Cor. 10:16). The Lord blessed the bread and wine, offered it to His disciples, and asked them to do the same. "*Do this in remembrance of me*" (Lk. 22:19).[1]

The Holy Eucharist is first of all the remembrance of Christ. But it is not a simple act of remembrance. Christ Himself is present. He calls us to live with Him His life, to live His sacrifice and Resurrection. He offers to us, and calls us to commune of, His Body and Blood. "*This is My Body, which is broken for you for the remission of sins. This is My Blood, which is shed for you and for the many, for the remission of sins*" (Mt. 26:26-29).

During the Eucharist we have before us no longer bread and wine, but the Body of Christ, which is broken into many for us, and the Blood of Christ, which is shed for us, for the remission of our sins. When we take the Holy Eucharist, we unite with Christ. And since we unite with Christ "mystically", we become one with all Christians, we all become one body, because we have all taken of the same Body, Christ. Union with Christ makes our existence spiritually. It leads us into the beauty and glory of the Kingdom of God. The Holy Eucharist brings Paradise into our life.

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[1] Lk. 22:19-20 – **"Gave thanks"** has at its root the Greek word 'Eucharist', which immediately came to refer to both the Liturgy and Sacrament of Holy Communion. Before the end of the first century, a manuscript called the 'Didache' refers to the celebration of the Liturgy as "the Eucharist," and in the year 150 AD, St. Justin says of Holy Communion, "This food we call 'Eucharist' of which no one is allowed to partake except one who believes that the things we teach are true, and has received the washing [Holy Baptism] for forgiveness of sins and of rebirth, and who lives as Christ commanded us."

"This is My Body": The Orthodox Church has always accepted Christ's words as true, "that the food consecrated by the word of prayer which comes from Him is the flesh and blood of that incarnate Jesus" (St. Justin). Jn. 6:51-66

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Why is the Sacrament of the Eucharist so important?

- It is the mystery of being united with God through which the soul knows Triune God and loves Him and responds to His Works.
- It is the mystery of thanksgiving by which we obtain the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ's life. It is a heavenly meal that grants us eternal life.
- As stated in the Book of Acts 20:7,8 "*On the first day of the week we came together to break bread. ... There were many lamps in the upstairs room where we were meeting.*" The Holy Eucharist gives real life. As the Lord Jesus Christ says: "*I tell you the truth, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you*" (John 6:53). The Holy Eucharist also gives eternal life: "*Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day. For my flesh is real food and my blood is real drink. Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood remains in me, and I in him. Just as the living Father sent me and I live because of the Father, so the one who feeds on me will live because of me. This is the bread that came down from heaven. Your forefathers ate manna and died, but he who feeds on this bread will live forever.*" John 6:54-58)
- Abiding in the Lord Jesus Christ according to His precious promise: "*He who eats My Flesh, and drinks My Blood abides in Me, and I in him*" (John 6:56) and becoming members of His Body (Ephesians 5:30).
- It gives us the promise of eternal life: "Whoever eats My Flesh and drinks My Blood has eternal life and I will raise him up at the last day. He who eats this Bread will live forever" (Jn. 6:54,58).
- It provides growth in the Spirit and spiritual perfection and life in Jesus Christ, for He said: "For My Flesh is food indeed and My Blood is drink indeed (Jn. 6:55, 57).
- It provides preparation to the soul, body, and spirit, as we say in the Offertory Mystery (it is the part of a Eucharistic service): "That they (Holy Body and Precious Blood) may become to us all for participation and healing and salvation for our souls, bodies and our spirits".
- As Communion received worthily and with preparation results in health and strength for our bodies and souls also partaking of the Communion without worthiness causes weakness, sickness and death (1 Cor. 11:30).
- Communion gives the person immunity against sin. "You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies" (Ps. 23:5).

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Biblical Contexts

As the Holy Bible references to the Holy Eucharist offer basic understanding about this Holy Sacrament, we can observe some of the New Testament references to the Holy Eucharist. These references are observed in the light of Jesus Christ's death and resurrection with all of them relating to the Last Supper.

The Epistles of St Paul and all Gospels mentioned how the Last Supper was celebrated before our Lord Jesus Christ's death and resurrection. The Last Supper is presented in the rite of the Jewish Passover. For example, the Gospel of Matthew records how the apostles prepared to celebrate the Passover Supper (Mt 26:17-19). That night as it grew dark Jesus Christ was at table with the twelve disciples when Jesus Christ instituted the Mystery of the Holy Eucharist,

> While they were eating, Jesus took bread, and when he had given thanks, he broke it and gave it to his disciples, saying, "Take and eat; this is my body." Then he took a cup, and when he had given thanks, he gave it to them, saying, "Drink from it, all of you. This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins. I tell you, I will not drink from this fruit of the vine from now on until that day when I drink it new with you in my Father's kingdom." When they had sung a hymn, they went out to the Mount of Olives. (Mt 26: 26-30).

Our Lord Jesus Christ at the Last Supper of course lovingly gave to His disciples the basis for the Holy Eucharistic rite, especially as He commanded the disciples to repeat what He had done. This command is obviously revealed in the Gospel of Luke 22:19. The faithful need to be ready for understanding these words by referring to the Gospel of John (Chapter 6). Our Lord Jesus Christ had promised in His unique services that He would give to the disciples "bread that would last for ever", that He was "the Bread of Life", that "His flesh was real food and His blood real drink." "I am the living bread that has come down from heaven. Whoever eats of this bread will live forever; and the bread that I shall give is my flesh for the life of the world" (John 6:51). This chapter (John 6) needs to be understood in the perspective of the Last Supper where Jesus Christ gives Himself to all faithful.

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Following this feast of the Last Supper, Our Lord Jesus Christ entered into His passion and death, a perfect sacrifice on behalf of us (Adam). In the Epistle of Corinth St. Paul revealed the meaning of Jesus Christ's death in relation to the Last Supper. He describes:

> For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took bread, and when he had given thanks, he broke it and said, "This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me." In the same way, after supper he took the cup, saying, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me." For whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes (1Cor 11:23-26).

The Lord Jesus Christ's death was one of offering the perfect sacrifice. In giving Himself to the disciples He was giving them a share in all that His death and resurrection would reach, which was the salvation of all humanity. In obedience to the Lord Jesus Christ command, the Church is always celebrating the Holy Eucharist proclaiming the death and resurrection of the Lord Jesus Christ's until He comes again.

In general, Holy Eucharist is also a Praise, Worship and Sacrifice of Thanksgiving, which we offer to the Almighty God, for His loving kindness and goodness. In this Sacrifice of Blessing the faithful joins with the clergy (bishop, priest, deacon), taking part in the singing or following it in spirit.

The Divine Liturgy

The Sacrament of Holy Eucharist is called Divine Liturgy. "Liturgy comes from the Greek term *leitourgia,* used in the Greek version of the Old Testament (the Septuagint) for the service of God by his people in general or, more specifically, for the service rendered in and around the temple by the priests and Levites" (Payton, 2007, p.173). As Payton identifies that Liturgy illustrates "what the people of God do- namely, worship Him" (Payton, 2007, p.173). The Ethiopian Orthodox *Tewahedo* Church has used the Geez term "***Kiddasse***" which means "***Praise***" or "***Thanksgiving***".

Divine Liturgy is a congregational prayer in Church because it is distinctive prayer in that: -

* Divine Liturgy
- Kiddasse "praise" or Thanksgiving
- Sacrificial prayer
- a congregational prayer in church
- EUChristic Liturgy

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- Divine Liturgy is called a "sacrificial prayer". As the Lord Jesus Christ says "I am the living bread that came down from heaven. Everyone who eats some of this bread will live forever. The bread is my body. I will give it for the life of the world." (Jn. Chapter 6 verses 51, NIV). (New International version)
- The Body Jesus Christ has been sacrificed in the Church. "Holy Communion means offering of sacrifices" (The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church Faith, 1996:39). It has biblical foundation (1 Cor. 11:23-25) and was founded by Jesus Christ.

  "*While they were eating, Jesus took bread, gave thanks and broke it, and gave it to his disciples, saying, Take it; this is my body. Then he took the cup, gave thanks and offered it to them, and they all drank from it. This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many, he said to them. I tell you the truth, I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it anew in the kingdom of God.*" (Mk. 14:22-25 NIV)

Eucharistic Liturgy mirrors various actions, both symbolic and actual found in the Old and New Testaments. "The sheep and goats were offered as sacrifices in the altars during the Old Testament times. However, these were preceding examples of the offering of the flesh and blood of Christ during the New Testament. […] The sacrifices which the Israelites offered during the day of their liberation exemplify Christ our Pascal lamb" (Payton, 2007, p.173).

* Chan says "The task of liturgical theology is to demonstrate how the liturgy serves in its particular way as transparency for the mystery of salvation. […] The one mystery of Christian faith is the Triune God in his self-communication to humanity. […] In different ways, the forms of liturgy express the conviction of faith that the Triune God, in their economic activity, is the mystery of Christian worship" (Chan, 2006, p.58).

* Ware (1997, p.266) clarifies "The Orthodox approach to religion is fundamentally a liturgical approach, which understands doctrine in the context of divine worship: it is no coincidence that the word 'Orthodoxy' should signify alike right belief and right worship, for the two things are inseparable. It has been truly said of the Byzantines: Dogma with them is not only an intellectual system apprehended by the clergy and expounded to laity, but a field of vision wherein all things on earth are seen in their relation to things in heaven, first and foremost through liturgy celebration." Considering the magnificence of the Orthodox Church worship, Ware has shown us that among some aspects of Orthodox worship, it is easy to discern

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spiritual and divine support. He also describes "Worship for the Orthodox Church, is nothing else than heaven on earth" (Ibid., 265). The heavenly and angelic liturgical worship is conducted on earth on the same altar and sacrifice in order that though the church heaven may be established on earth through its service. At the same time as the faithful of the church join in the Orthodox Holy Liturgy, their hearts are raised up above, connecting themselves and communing with the heavenly beings.

The Eucharistic Liturgy is established in the figure of "the heavenly worship of angels". It has been described by the prophet Isaiah as follows:

> "In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord seated on a throne, high and exalted, and the train of his robe filled the temple. Above him were seraphs, each with six wings: With two wings they covered their faces, with two they covered their feet, and with two they were flying. And they were calling to one another: Holy, holy, holy is the LORD Almighty; the whole earth is full of his glory." (Is. 6:1-3 NIV)

The Angels glorify the Lord, and the Eucharistic Liturgy takes place as the similar way. The Church also glorifies the Lord in the same way in the Liturgical service.

As the Evangelist John says,

> "Another angel, who had a golden censer, came and stood at the altar. He was given much incense to offer, with the prayers of all the saints, on the golden altar before the throne. The smoke of the incense, together with the prayers of the saints, went up before God from the angel's hand." (Rev. 8:3-4 NIV)

The Church also celebrates Divine Liturgy in the way of angelic worship. The above biblical evidence points out that there are many connections between the angelic and the Church worship. There is place of worship and alter in heaven, as there is the Church on earth. "There is the temple of the tabernacle of witness" (Johnson, 2004:286) in both, and "God is already there. Heaven is the throne of God; the earth is the footstool of God" (Barclay, 2001:184).

As Germmanus referred by Barker declares: "The church is an earthly heaven, in which the super-celestial God dwells and walks about. This must be the Garden of Eden, which was represented in the temple by the great hall. After comparing the apse to the cave of Christ's birth and burial and the table to the place where his dead body rested, he continues: 'The holy table is also the throne of God on which, borne by cherubim, he rested in the body… The alter is and is called the heavenly and spiritual altar where the earthly and material priests

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who always assist and serve the Lord represent the spiritual, serving and hierarchical power" (Barker, 2004:385). In the Orthodox theological teaching, "the church is the earthly heaven in which the heavenly God dwells and moves" (Ware, 264).

Discussion Point

- Why is the Sacrament of Holy Eucharist called Divine Liturgy?

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Chapter Three

Sacramental Theology: Spiritual and Reparative Life in Our God and Savior Jesus Christ

- **Holy Sacrament of Confession**
- **Holy Sacrament of Anointing of the Sick**

Week Ten

Objectives

- To go into the depths of the Sacrament of Confession to return our life to our Lord Jesus Christ.

The Holy Sacrament of Confession

Background

Confession and forgiveness are key parts of rites in Orthodox Christians worship (Payton, 2007). Some time, they can be seen in social life.

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Definitions of Confession

The term 'Confession' ('Repentance' or 'Penance' in Greek, *metanoia* or *exomologisis*)" (Ware, 1997) is described as the "acknowledgment of one's guilt for all the evil that he has committed" (Tyneh, 2003). Confession is a Sacrament, or Mystery, of the Church, a way in which we can experience God in His fullness here on earth. When we sin, we damage our relationship with God. Sin ultimately separates us from God, from our fellow human beings, and from our own true characters. During Confession, we acknowledge our sins out loud to God in the presence of the priest.

Sin is also defined as the omission of an action, thought, or statement or, thought, or statement that the person regards as a wrongdoing and that causes the person concern. However, "[In the Orthodox Church] sin is identified not with transgression and guilt, but with failure and missing the mark" (Manley, 1990).

Darrow quoted by Sharma put it this way, "Sin … is an offence against God, a transgression against the divine law and any thought, desire, word, act or omission against that law" (Sharma, 1998). A confession can be communicated orally, in letters, or in the view of the sinner. The repentant and the spiritual father (father confessor) are the main participants in the Sacrament of Confession. The penitent is the person confessing the sin.

The sacrament of Confession is our formal act of reconciliation with God in the Church when sin has severed us from the Church's life. Because Confession is the way to communion with God when that communion has been broken by sin, it is often referred to in Church Tradition as the reestablishment of that condition of life with God which was given to human beings in the basic sacraments of inauguration into the Christian life.

Historical Background of Sacrament of Confession

The sacrament of Confession exists in the Church to allow for the repentance and reconversion of Christians who have fallen away from the life of faith. There are three main elements to the act of formal Confession.

- The first is a sincere sorrow for sins and for the breaking of communion with God.
- The second is an open and heartfelt confession of sins.

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- The third element of penance is the formal prayer of absolution through which the forgiveness of God through Christ is sacramentally bestowed upon the repentant sinner.

The reason of the sacrament of confession or Repentance in the Church is to offer the faithful who have sinned with the opportunity to return to God.

"But your iniquities have separated you from your God", say the prophet Isaiah 59:2.

Subsequently Confession is returning to God.

God says: "Ever since the time of your forefathers you have turned away from my decrees and have not kept them. Return to me, and I will return to you" (Mal 3:7).

The parable of the Lost Son in Luke 15:18-20 identifies the lost son returned to his father when he repented. The real confession in Church is the individual's desire to return to that original state obtained through baptism.

Confession is also reconciliation with the Almighty God. This is what Saint Paul confirms:

> "We are therefore Christ's ambassadors, as though God were making his appeal through us. We implore you on Christ's behalf: Be reconciled to God. God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:20-21 NIV).

So, through this sacrament, the repentants can restore their relationship with the Almighty God by avoiding their sin. They receive eternal life. As St. Paul states:

> "For the wage of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord" (Rom. 6:23).

According to the authority given by the Lord Jesus Christ to His disciples to forgive the repentants who truly return to God and believe in Him, the repentants receive forgiveness of sins through the meditation of the priest when the penitents come to him and confess. This sacrament was instituted by the Lord Christ:

> "And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven; whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven" (Mt. 16:18-19). The Lord also gave this authority the apostles (Mt.18: 18).

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The Orthodox Church believes that the keys of authority to receive confessions and forgiveness of sins have been transferred to the ordained bishops and priests. Ware says:

> "In Orthodoxy confession are heard, not in a closed confessional with a grille separating confessor and penitent, but in any convenient part of the church, usually in the open immediately in front of iconostasis; sometimes priest and penitent stand behind a screen, or there may be a special room in the church set apart of the confessions" (Ware, 1997). The sacrament of confession is also a confidential issue between the penitent and the priest.

Basis of Biblical Theology

The Rite of Confession in Old Testament Evidence

The Old Testament frequently speaks about repentance to illustrate the returning of Israel back to God, in answer to a promise of restored fortunes for the country. As the Lord appears to Solomon:

> "When I shut up the heavens so that there is no rain, or command locusts to devour the land or send a plague among my people, if my people, who are called by my name, will humble themselves and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then will I hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and will heal their land" (2 Chronicles 7: 13-14 NIV).

The Old Testament shows that confession is an essential act for the penitents who brought the sacrifice, laid their hands on its head and confessed their sins to God before the priest. The priest then took the sacrifice and slaughtered it, bringing it onto the altar of burnt sacrifice as penance for sin. God states:

> "If a person sins because he does not speak up when he hears a public charge to testify regarding something he has seen or learned about, he will be held responsible. … Or if a person thoughtlessly takes an oath to do anything, whether good or evil—in any matter one might carelessly swear about—even though he is unaware of it, in any case when he learns of it he will be guilty. When anyone is guilty in any of these ways, he must confess in what way he has sinned and, as a penalty for the sin he has committed, he must bring to the Lord a female lamb or goat from the flock as a sin offering; and the priest shall make atonement for him for his sin" (Leviticus 5:1-6).

Confession was being exercised in Old Testament tradition. This sacrament is a joy for penitence. King David sings: "Praise be to the LORD, who has not let us be torn by their teeth. We have escaped like a bird out of the fowler's snare; the snare has been broken, and we have escaped" (Ps 124:6-7 NIV).

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With confession the Lord gets rid of the inequity of the penitents, while saying to him: "Your inequity is taken away, and your sin purged" (Is. 6:7). It is the only way for removing our sins. As the Lord declares: "For I will forgive their wickedness and will remember their sins no more" (Jer 31:34). This Old Testament confession rite shows us the faithful seek forgiveness through confession. The Lord reveals to people His mercy through miracles of healing after they confess their sin and return to God (Jonah 3; 4).

The sacrament of confession in the Old Testament context suggests that the faithful must avoid their sins in a religious context and use these sacred scriptures to cope with individual sins. This tradition has been seen in New Testament contexts.

The Rite of Confession in the New Testament Evidence

In the New Testament, the rite of confession is significantly highlighted and given specific content for all faithful. This feature of teaching begins with the preaching of St. John the Baptist. He says: "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near" (Mt.3: 2 NIV). Then confession has been the call of the Lord Christ to the penitents into His kingdom. "From that time on Jesus began to preach, Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near (Mt. 4: 17). The Gospel of Matthew explains that St. Peter repented after he had denied Christ His master three times (Mt. 26: 31-35). In order to live always in purity of life, every penitent must participate in sacrament of confession.

The Apostles received the authority from our Lord Jesus Christ by saying, "I tell you the truth, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven" (Matthew 18:18). Our Lord also fulfilled His promise in John 20:21-23 NIV: "Again Jesus said, "Peace be with you! As the Father has sent me, I am sending you. And with that he breathed on them and said, "Receive the Holy Spirit. If you forgive anyone his sins, they are forgiven; if you do not forgive them, they are not forgiven." The Gospel of John sufficiently indicates the tradition of apostolic succession.

The apostles were preaching to all people to repent (Acts 2:38; Acts 13:38-41). The forgiveness of sin follows upon faith or repentance (Act. 3:19, 10:43). Faith and repentance are basically two features of the same passage, through it is true that, in the case of faith, the New Testament highlights the Saviour Jesus Christ (Acts 20:21). Therefore, like faith,

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repentance is regarded as a gift of God (Acts 5: 31; 2 Tim. 2:25). In general, the book of Acts shows how the Sacrament of Confession has been performed during the Apostles' period: "Many of those who believed now came and openly confessed their evil deeds." (Acts 19:18 NIV).

The New Testament commands the tradition: "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed" (James 5:16 NIV). In this part there is a real connection of confession with healing. St. John the apostle also says: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. If we claim we have not sinned, we make him out to be a liar and his word has no place in our lives" (1 Jn. 1:9).

Why do we need to repent at all?

When we sin, we distance ourselves from others emotionally, spiritually, and sometimes physically. After we confess to God, He wipes those sins away and allows us to draw closer to the family we have in Christ, the Church.

Confession is cathartic: After admitting our sins to God in the presence of the priest, we experience that relief that comes from "getting it off our chest."

Confession provides us with a diagnosis: How can we know we are sick, unless we go to a doctor regularly to ensure that we aren't? Frequent confession allows us to cleanse our souls of the evils we commit. The longer we stay away from the doctor, the higher our chances of becoming ill.

Forgiveness

Forgiveness is a practice and a conception in which religious and moral perspectives, responsibilities and sensibilities are closely related (Nielsen, Johnson & Ellis, 2001). The religious truth of forgiveness shows a definite relation between God and humanity. This firm relation is indicated by the holiness of God and by human fault that sin against God has been pardoned and true relation between God and humanity has been restored. In religious context, genuine confession of sin is necessary to receive for divine forgiveness. Moral context also

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highlights the real relation between forgiveness, love and justices (Tillich, 1960:121). Micah also says "He has showed you, O man, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6: 8)

According to the Old Testament, divine forgiveness commands genuine confession of sin by the penitent (Is. 11:2-5). A very helpful section for the entire Old Testament understanding of forgiveness is Exodus 34: 6-7 NIV, "The LORD, the LORD, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness, maintaining love to thousands, and forgiving wickedness, rebellion and sin. Yet he does not leave the guilty unpunished; he punishes the children and their children for the sin of the fathers to the third and fourth generation." Forgiveness is linked in the nature of God as merciful. His forgiveness is also not indiscriminate. He is Holy and has no attachment with evils. God Himself has said, "Be holy because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (Lev. 19: 2 NIV). The angels always glorify Him by saying, "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD Almighty; the whole earth is full of his glory" (Isa.6: 3 NIV). On the part of the faithful there is the need for penitence if they are to receive forgiveness of sins. Penitents receive forgiveness. As Coppedge identifies "Forgiveness is part of the blessing of a right relationship with God (Coppedge, 2001).

In Jeremiah 31:34 the Lord declares, "For I will forgive their wickedness and will remember their sins no more." Micah also talks about him as casting sins "into the depths of the sea" (Micah 7:19). These Old Testament accounts emphasize the completeness of God's forgiveness. When the Lord forgives, the sins of penitents are dealt with thoroughly.

Instead, the New Testament shows manifestations of forgiveness (Luke 6:27). In Matthew 26: 25-28 it is mentioned that the blood of Jesus Christ was shed "for many for the forgiveness of sins." Forgiveness shows the work of Christ. The Epistle of St. John says, "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. If we claim we have not sinned, we make him out to be a liar and his word has no place in our lives" (1 John 1: 9-10 NIV). Forgiveness has connection with faith. Forgiveness has also link with love. Nevertheless, the connection between love and forgiveness is firmly attached to the connection between love and justice (1 Tim. 6: 11-20; 1 Peter.2: 1-10; Heb. 4:8). The biblical context of forgiveness emphasizes the task of love through justices and forgiveness.

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In general, the Holy Bible clarifies that each sin can be forgiven however serious it may be, provided that the patients must return to the Lord in confession. As Prophet Isaiah recorded, "Come now, let us reason together, says the LORD. Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they are red as crimson, they shall be like wool" (Is 1: 18 NIV). It shows also that God is always forgives the patients. "Who wants all men to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim. 2:4 NIV).

Week Eleven

Objectives: Describing the origin and meaning of the sacrament and how to participate in it.

The Holy Sacrament of Anointing

The Sacrament of Anointing of the sick is one of the Church Sacraments through which the priest anoints the sick body requesting divine grace to heal both body and soul. It is not an ordinary way of healing sickness, and the healing authority is not just administered through the oil but to the prayer. The Apostle James talks about the Sacrament of Unction (James 5:14-15).

Holy Anointing is the sacrament of the spiritual, physical, and mental healing of a sick person whatever the nature or the gravity of the illness may be. The sacrament of anointing the sick has two kinds of outward signs. First, the oil with which the sick person is anointed. Before using, it should be consecrated through certain prayers. Second there is the prayer which is offered to God for healing the sick. In addition to this prayer, certain parts of the Bible are read. The invisible grace is the healing of body and soul. This grace is granted through this sacrament.

Biblical Contexts

Our Lord Jesus Christ showed love and care for us by healing the sick, raising the dead, making the deaf hear, the lame walk and giving sight to the blind. The Gospels show several times to Jesus Christ doing this. The Old Testament gives a ceremony of cleansing for the leper, and this involved the use of oil with an anointing by the High priest. Thus, it is not

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surprising that the use of oil would carry on with the coming of Jesus Christ. Christ continues His power of healing to the disciples. In Gospel of Mark 6:13 one looks at, "They (the twelve) cast out many demons, and anointed with oil many who were sick and cured them." Therefore, this sacrament is in line with Jesus' empowering the twelve to heal the sick. More evidence comes from the writings in the Epistle of James:

> Are any among you suffering? They should pray. Are any cheerful? They should sing songs of praise. Are any among you sick? They should call for the elders of the church and have them pray over them, anointing them with oil in the name of the Lord. The prayer of faith will save the sick, and the Lord will raise them up, and anyone who has committed sin will be forgiven (James 5:13-15).

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Length of Teaching: (Total: 14 Weeks)
Class Taught by Abba Hailegebriel Girma (PhD, EdD)
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Chapter Four

Sacramental Theology: Service Life in Our God and Savior Jesus Christ

- **Holy Sacrament of Ordination**(ክህነት)
- **Holy Sacrament of Marriage** (ተክሊል)

Week Twelve

The Holy Sacrament of Ordination(ክህነት)

Objectives

To understand the role of the sacrament of priesthood(ኅላፍ) in the Church

Scriptural Verse

"And no man takes this honor(ክብሩን) to himself, but he who is called by God, just as Aaron was." (Heb. 5:4)

Spiritual Meaning of Priesthood(ኅላፍ)

Ordination, which means "setting in place" or "selection by the outstretched hand(ኣኽ መዘርጋ)," is one of the Orthodox sacraments. The Sacrament of Holy Orders is also one of the Church Sacraments through which the clergy receive power to administer the sacraments and celebrate other spiritual services. In the Old and New Testaments, priests are chosen by God.

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"I give your priesthood to you as a gift for service, but the outsider who comes near shall be put to death." (Numbers 18:7)

- When King Saul dared to raise the burnt offering, he was rejected (1 Samuel 13:9)
- King Uzziah dared to raise the incense and remained a leper till his death. (2 Chronicles. 26:19-21)

The Sacrament of Holy Orders is a sacred sign, accompanied by spiritual ceremonies. This sacrament has two types of visible signs; the first sign is the laying on of hands. Bishop performs this sign (1 Tim. 5: 22). The second sign is the prayers of consecration (Acts 6: 6; 14:23). According to the New Testament, the ordained clergy receive a Divine gift appropriate to the service. As 2 Timothy 1:6 records, "*For this reason, I remind you to fan into flame the gift of God, which is in you through the laying on of my hands.*" The Holy Spirit gives this invisible gift to the clergy to perform their duties.

As known, the sacraments are instituted by Christ Himself (John 1:16,17) including ordination (Mark 3:14; Acts 1:15-26; 6:1-6; 1 Tim. 3:1-13; 4:14). The Sacrament of Holy Orders is also instituted by our Lord Jesus Christ when He chose the Twelve and consecrated them for ministry (Lk. 6:13 and (Mt. 10:5-8).

- This sacrament gives authority of absolution and binding (Mt. 18:18; Jn.20:22-23).
- It gives authority for baptizing and teaching the commandments (Matthew 28: 19-20).
- It gives authority to deal with the Holy Body and Precious Blood (Luke 22: 14-20).

Ranks of Priesthood

The appointing of the apostles sets forth the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ in calling people to ministry. Holy Ordination is the sacramental act of setting an individual apart for the ministry of the Church by the laying on of hands of a bishop. The Sacrament of Holy Ordination takes its name from the fact that bishops, priests, and deacons give order to the Church. There are three ordination names which are bishop, priest and deacon. They are known as members of the clergy because, by means of the Sacrament of the Holy Orders, they receive the Holy Spirit's Grace for holy service in the Church. It is the Church's teaching and belief that the clergy must strive to fulfill the Holy Spirit's grace conferred upon them at ordination.

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The **bishops** are the leading members of the clergy in that they have the responsibility to defend the Church doctrine and to manage the Church services. A bishop has the authority to ordain and to perform other Church sacraments.

Through the level of Orthodox Spirituality - **Perfection – Spirit (ንጽሐ ልቡና)**, Bishops need to be perfect. It is being in union with the truth and living the truth itself. This is the level of one's mystical union with God (*Theosis or Deification*).

Simon the New Theologian also asserts that **Bishops** must be perfect without which they should not be consecrated as bishops.

The **priests** of the Church are those who assist the bishop in his work. They celebrate the Divine Liturgy, teach, preach, counsel, visit the sick, and exercise the ministries of forgiveness and healing.

Through the level of Orthodox Spirituality - **Contemplation - Soul (ንጽሐ ነፍስ)**, priests need to focus on understanding the truth.

Simon the New Theologian states that Priests must achieve the level of contemplation without which they should not be ordained as priests.

The **deacons** of the Church assist the priests in the Divine Liturgy, other Church services and good deeds and works of charity.

Through the level of Orthodox Spirituality - **Purification – Flesh (ንጽሐ ሥጋ)**, deacons need to immoralities and grow with virtues.

Simon the New Theologian says that deacons must be purified without which they should not be ordained as a deacon. They need to be examples.

Conclusion

The sacrament of priesthood is vital to the apostolic churches and is rooted in Holy Scripture. Our Lord Jesus Christ ordained His disciples granting them the Episcopal Authority (Jn. 20:20-23). This Holy breath is still upheld and is handed over from generation to generation.

perfection-Spirit (ንጽሐ ልቡና)
Contemplation-Soul (ንጽሐ ነፍስ)
Purification-Flesh (ንጽሐ ሥጋ)

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The bishop breathes on the ordained open mouth and says, "Receive the Holy Spirit" and he replies, "I opened my mouth and for myself, I attracted a Spirit".

Week Thirteen

Holy Sacrament of Marriage (Matrimony)

Objectives

To understand the meaning of Christian marriage and to understand the spiritual significance of the marriage ceremony.

Scriptural Verse

"So then, they are no longer two but one flesh. Therefore, what God has joined together, let not man separate" (Mt. 19:6)

Marriage

Our Lord Jesus Christ gave a very specific meaning and significance to human marriage. Following the Old Testament Law but going beyond its formal precepts, Our Lord Jesus Christ taught the uniqueness of human marriage as the most perfect natural expression of God's love for humans, and of His own love for the Church.

Marriage is simply the creation of a church, a temple for the Holy Spirit, or a manger for the Lord to live in. When the Lord said, "Where two (the husband and wife) or three (the husband, wife, and child) are gathered together in My Name, I am there in the midst of them" (Mt. 18: 20), He was speaking of the family as a small model of the Church. The Unity in Christian marriage is not accomplished in a magical way but through the participation of the bride and groom through their prayers and their positive response to the work of Grace. The work of the Holy Spirit makes two individuals into a couple and one entity.

In the sacrament of marriage, a man and a woman are given the possibility to become one spirit and one flesh in a way which no human love can provide by itself. In Christian

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marriage the Holy Spirit is given so that what is begun on earth does not "part in death" but is fulfilled and continues most perfectly in the Kingdom of God.

Characteristics of the Christian Marriage

Christian Marriage shows 'unity'.

- Marriage is not a contract between two people but two people unified in love, sacrifice, and harmony, with no more duality:
  - Spirit - the two are united in God.
  - Mind - the two have the mind of Christ.
  - Emotion - It is more blessed to give than to receive.
  - Will - The Holy Spirit is the leader of each of their will.

Continuity

- No divorce except for adultery and denial of faith.
- The Church authorizes the annulment of Matrimony in case of infidelity (Mt. 19: 3- 8)

Bearing Fruit

- Christian Virtues - reflected in their lives.
- Children, if any - blessed and raised in the fear of God
- Service and good deeds - to everyone around them

The Purpose of the Sacrament of Holy Matrimony

The Sacrament of Holy Matrimony is the sacred service through which a man and a woman are united and given the divine grace which blesses their marital union, makes it perfect and spiritual like the unity of Christ and Church, and gives them strength (Mt. 19:4-6). The purpose of this sacrament is to bless the matrimonial union. As Saint Paul describes, marriage is considered a 'Mystery' (Ephesus 5:25-32).

> Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, in order to make her holy by cleansing her with the washing of water by the word so as to present the church to himself in splendor, without a spot or wrinkle or anything of the kind—yes, so that she may be holy and without blemish. In the same

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way husbands should love their wives as they do their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. For no one ever hates his own body, but nourishes and tenderly cares for it, just as Christ does for the church, because we are members of his body. For this reason, a man will leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become one flesh. This is a great mystery, and I am applying it to Christ and the church.

The Sacrament of Holy Matrimony is the sacrament through which man and woman are united through the grace of the Holy Spirit, and it is also true symbolic of the profound union of man and woman in our Lord Jesus Christ.

Conclusion

Marriage is a Holy Sacrament in the Orthodox Church because in it the Holy Spirit unites the two into one. Therefore, this marriage is expected to continue even when a couple is faced with difficult circumstances. The ritual of the marriage ceremony is filled with deep spiritual meaning to remind us of the importance of this unity before God and our responsibility towards keeping this unity while being spiritually fruitful.

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